

The Missed Line Items Checklist

Residential remodel estimating — the costs that don't show up until they're yours.

Free. No email required. Copy it, print it, paste it into your own spreadsheet.

How to use this

Run this list against a bid you have already priced — not against a blank page. The point is not to add every line. The point is to make you say "wait" out loud about four or five of them. Those are the ones that were going to come out of your margin.

Each item says what it is and **when it bites**, because a checklist without the consequence is just more paperwork.

1. Before the first day (pre-construction)

#	Line item	When it bites
1	Permit fees and the hours spent pulling them	Municipality charges by valuation; you priced the fee, not the two mornings at the counter
2	Plan revisions after plan check comments	Reviewer wants a detail; your designer bills hourly; nobody budgeted it
3	Engineering letter for a beam or header	Discovered at demo, needed before inspection, stops the job for a week
4	Existing-conditions survey / as-built measure	You bid off the client's sketch and it was wrong by 4 inches
5	HOA or historic-district approval time	Not a cost line, a schedule line — carrying costs while you wait
6	Utility locate and any private locate fee	Public locate is free; private side isn't, and you own the damage if you skip it
7	Asbestos / lead survey on pre-1980 work	Legally required in most jurisdictions; testing is cheap, discovering it mid-demo is not
8	Insurance certificate endorsements the client's building requires	Condo boards ask for extra insured; broker charges per certificate

2. Site access, protection, logistics

#	Line item	When it bites
9	Floor, stair and rail protection for the path to the work	Every occupied remodel; damage claims start here

#	Line item	When it bites
10	Dust containment: zip walls, negative air, filter changes	Client with allergies or a toddler will make this your problem
11	Parking: permits, meters, tickets, or paying for a space	Urban jobs; a ticket a day for six weeks is a real number
12	Long carry / stair carry for material and debris	Third-floor walk-up doubles labor on drywall and tile without warning
13	Elevator reservation and building access fees	Condos charge for the padded elevator and the doorman's time
14	Temporary power, temporary heat, temporary toilet	Winter work stalls without heat; nobody prices the propane
15	Storage of client's furniture / owner's material	"Just put it in the garage" until the garage is the work area
16	Security of tools and material on an occupied site	Lockbox, job box, or the cost of replacing what walks off

3. Demolition and the unknowns behind it

#	Line item	When it bites
17	Selective demo labor separate from bulk demo	Saving a wall costs more than removing it; bulk pricing hides this
18	Dumpster pulls — the second and third one	Everyone prices one dumpster. Nobody prices the swap-outs
19	Disposal surcharges: mattresses, appliances, tile, concrete	Landfills charge by material class, not just weight
20	Hazmat disposal if the survey comes back positive	Separate hauler, manifest, and certified disposal
21	Unforeseen framing repair: rot, termite, prior bad work	The allowance you didn't set becomes the change order they fight
22	Bringing existing wiring, venting, or plumbing to current code	Inspector triggers it; the client thinks you should have known
23	Patching where the old work ends and yours begins	The "feather-out" line — drywall, flooring, and paint transitions
24	Temporary shoring for a load-bearing change	Priced with the beam, forgotten as a separate labor day

4. The trades most often under-scoped

#	Line item	When it bites
25	Electrical: AFCI/GFCI upgrades triggered by the work	Code requires it in the circuits you touch; not in the fixture count
26	Electrical: panel capacity check, and the upgrade if it fails	New induction range or heat pump exceeds the service
27	Plumbing: relocating a vent or stack, not just the fixture	Moving a toilet more than a few inches becomes a floor-framing job
28	Plumbing: shutoff valves, supply lines, escutcheons	Small parts, always excluded from the fixture package, always needed
29	HVAC: return air sizing when you add or close a room	Fails inspection or the room never heats and you get called back
30	HVAC: duct sealing / register relocation after ceiling work	Priced as "existing to remain" until it isn't
31	Framing: blocking for grab bars, TVs, cabinets, curtain rods	Costs almost nothing during framing, costs a wall opening later
32	Insulation at exterior walls opened during the work	Code upgrade at any wall you expose; easy to miss in the takeoff
33	Fire caulking / draft stopping at penetrations	Inspector's favorite; cheap material, unpriced labor
34	Subfloor prep: leveling, underlayment, deflection fix	Tile fails without it; discovered after demo

5. Finishes — where allowances leak

#	Line item	When it bites
35	Tile waste factor for pattern, size, and layout	10% is not enough for herringbone or a large-format floor
36	Trim and transition pieces (bullnose, Schluter, thresholds)	Priced per square foot; the edges are per linear foot
37	Setting materials by substrate: membrane, thinset, grout, sealer	The tile is the allowance; the system around it is not
38	Paint: primer coat on new drywall, plus the ceiling	"Two coats" quoted for walls only
39	Paint: color changes and accent walls after the fact	Client picks three colors where you priced one
40	Cabinet modifications: fillers, panels, scribing to out-of-square walls	No wall is square in a remodel; the box price assumes it is
41	Countertop template visit, seam decision, cutout charges	Fabricator bills each cutout and each visit

#	Line item	When it bites
42	Appliance install labor and the parts kits	Especially dishwasher, hood, and anything gas
43	Hardware: knobs, pulls, hinges, closers	Small dollars, guaranteed to be excluded and needed on the last day
44	Interior door slabs: hanging, trimming, hardware boring	The door is cheap, the labor isn't

6. The invisible costs of running the job

#	Line item	When it bites
45	Your own supervision hours, per week, priced at a real rate	The single biggest missed line in owner-operator estimating
46	Material pickup runs and delivery fees	Two runs a week for eight weeks, plus your truck and your time
47	Restocking fees and return trips for wrong material	Happens on every job; treat it as a percentage, not an accident
48	Punch list labor after "completion"	Always exists, rarely a line item
49	Final clean, plus the pre-final clean nobody counts	Two cleans on most jobs; you priced one
50	Callback and warranty reserve	If your callbacks cost 1% of revenue, price 1%
51	Client meeting and selection-support time	Selection paralysis is billable time or it is your evening
52	Change-order administration time	Writing, pricing and chasing signatures is labor
53	Photo documentation and progress reporting	Required by many contracts; someone has to do it

7. Money, risk and timing

#	Line item	When it bites
54	Sales tax on materials — where it applies and who pays	Varies by state and by contract type; assume wrong and it's your margin
55	Payment processing fees if the client pays by card	3% of a large draw is a real line
56	Financing / carrying cost of material bought before the draw	You are the bank between purchase and payment
57	Price escalation clause on long-lead material	Quotes expire in 30 days; jobs don't
58	Long-lead items and the schedule gap they create	Windows and cabinets set the critical path
59	Contingency for the parts of the scope you truly cannot see	Not a fudge factor — a disclosed line with a defined trigger

#	Line item	When it bites
60	Escalation for work in occupied homes vs. vacant	Slower, dirtier, more interruption; measure it once, apply it always
61	Winter / weather days on any exterior scope	Schedule risk that becomes a supervision cost
62	Bonding or lien waiver processing, where required	Administrative and sometimes a real fee
63	Overhead recovery — rent, insurance, phone, software, truck	Markup is not profit until overhead is covered

The one habit worth more than the list

Write down your estimated number for each phase. When the job closes, write the actual next to it. Do it for five jobs.

You will find that you are not randomly wrong. You are **consistently** wrong in the same two or three places — and by roughly the same percentage. That number is more valuable than any template, because it is yours.

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